

**NEWSPAPER COVERAGE OF NIGERIAN ARMY BRUTALITY ON CIVILIANS: A STUDY
OF 2020 ENDSARS PROTEST AT LEKKI TOLL-GATE, LAGOS - AN ASSESSMENT OF THE
PUNCH AND THE NATION NEWSPAPER (OCTOBER 2020-MARCH 2021)**

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**A RESEARCH PROJECT WRITTEN AND SUBMITTED TO THE DEPARTMENT OF
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DECLARATION

I, MELEKI IDRIS ADEGBOYEGA, now affirm that this project “**NEWSPAPER COVERAGE OF NIGERIAN ARMY BRUTALITY ON CIVILIANS: A STUDY OF 2020 ENDSARS PROTEST AT LEKKI TOLL-GATE, LAGOS - AN ASSESSMENT OF THE PUNCH AND THE NATION NEWSPAPER (OCTOBER 2020- MARCH 2021)**” is my effort and creation. This research work is a product of my intellectual investigation and is not copied from any past research work; I also declare that both published and unpublished materials directly used in the research are appropriately attributed.

Signature.....

Date.....

CERTIFICATION

This is to certify that this research study, named ‘**NEWSPAPER COVERAGE OF NIGERIAN ARMY BRUTALITY ON CIVILIANS: A STUDY OF 2020 ENDSARS PROTEST AT LEKKI TOLL-GATE, LAGOS - AN ASSESSMENT OF THE PUNCH AND THE NATION NEWSPAPER (OCTOBER 2020-MARCH 2021)**’ was carried out by **MELEKI IDRIS ADEGBOYEGA** with the matric number **21/9115** in the Department of Mass Communication, College of Communication and Media Studies, Caleb University, Lagos. The research work is regarded adequate in partial fulfillment of the requirement for the award of a Bachelor of Sciences (B.Sc.) degree in Mass Communication.

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DEDICATION

I dedicate this research work to almighty Allah, whose divine kindness and endless wisdom have shown me the way. His guidance has been the cornerstone of my perseverance, turning obstacle into opportunity and fueling my commitment into excellence. I also dedicate it to my beloved mother and my amazing siblings, whose love, encouragement and nonstop support have been my greatest motivation during this journey. I also dedicate this research work with deepest love and respect to my late father Mr. Surajudeen Meleki whose memory remains a source of deep inspiration, though you are not physically present but your spirit lives on in every word, every thought and every effort I have put into this work. You're my first cheerleader that believed in me when I doubted myself and your faith gives me the courage to keep pushing forward. I dedicate to the cherished memory of Mr. Folarin Owo-Odusi, whose love, wisdom and inspiration continue to guide my path. To my supervisor, Prof. Charles Nwachukwu, for his guidance and support have been instrumental in shaping this work.

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ABSTRACT

Media plays an important role in shaping public opinion and influencing policy decisions in democratic societies. This research work was motivated by the important roles of media in pointing out human rights issues, especially in situations involving the military. The idea for this study came from the concern over how the media reported the Nigerian Army's actions during the 2020 Endsars protest in Lagos. The main objective of the study was to evaluate the frequency of coverage of army brutality incidents during the 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki toll gate in the selected newspaper, to analyze how Punch and The Nation newspapers framed the army brutality story during the 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki toll gate and to ascertain the level of prominence given to stories on army brutality during the 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki toll gate. The researcher employed agenda-setting theory and framing theory to stabilize the research work and to also show how media coverage can shape public understanding and influence the importance placed on different issues. A quantitative research approach was used with content analysis for data gathering. The researcher analyzed 260 editions from October 2020 to March 2021 and found out that both newspapers paid attention to the issue but the stories were placed in less prominent sections it did not receive the front page attention expected for such a critical issue. This study contributes to understanding the role of the media in promoting human rights and accountability.

Keywords: Newspaper Coverage, Army Brutality, Civilians, Endsars Protest

CHAPTER ONE

INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background to the Study

According to Davisson (2014), newspapers are periodicals that come out regularly, usually every day, and have current news, opinions, feature stories, and ads that can be bought. Similar to other media, its main purpose is to teach, educate, enlighten, entertain, and keep an eye on things. In spite of this, it has the amazing ability to stay powerful over time. It is important to remember that the early days and growth of the Nigerian press are a historical process that involved many people who didn't know what their work would lead to. In 1846, the Presbyterian Mission in Calabar, Nigeria, set up a printing press with the goal of raising the literary level of the people who lived there by encouraging them to write short articles on a wide range of topics, mostly religious ones. This was the start of print journalism in Nigeria. In spite of the fact that the Calabar attempt failed, it was the first step toward making newspapers in Nigeria. Rev. Henry Townsend, a missionary who later became a journalist, built his own printing press and started a printing school on the missionary property in Abeokuta in 1854. He began a newspaper called *Iwe Iroyin* in 1854. This was the first newspaper, which was for the reading pleasure of the Egba people. Before it ceased to run in 1867, its circulation was roughly 3,000 per day. The first newspaper issued by a Nigerian was by Kitoye Agasa in Lagos in 1914, a pro-government paper that was disliked by many. In 1921, Ernest Ikoli formed the *Africa Messenger*, which only ran for five years (Skogan, 2018).

This study named “Newspaper Coverage of Nigerian Army Brutality on Civilians: A study of 2020 EndSars in Lekki, Lagos - An Assessment of The Punch and The Nation Newspaper (Oct 2020 - March 2021),” will investigate reportage of the listed media and how the media behave as

the conscience of the society it finds itself in. Brutality as a social phenomenon is a vital component of all human life, in other words, it's an important issue to be addressed in the society. Nigeria has thus been referred to as one of the most prone countries in the world because of her low social security level and social activities, which are against the law in nature. Brutality can be considered physical violence; great cruelty or an instance of cruel and violent treatment or behavior (Fishman,2017).

According to Balcells and Stanton (2020), Army brutality against civilians broadly refers to any acts that, through the use of force, harm or damage civilians or civilian targets, including violence that kills and violence that doesn't kill. Although illegal, it can be performed under the color of law. However, army violence, a longstanding civil rights issue, has returned to the forefront of Nigerian public debate (Garafalo, 2018).

The Nigerian Army (NA) is the major component of the Nigerian Armed Forces, they are in charge of land fighting and keeping the country's borders safe. For national security and keeping the peace within a country, especially in battle zones, the army is very important. It was started in 1960, after Nigeria got its freedom, and has grown into a strong force that works both inside and outside of Nigeria. (Joshua et al, 2021).

There have been various incidents in Nigeria in which security agents, with the cooperation of the government, exploited the privileges of their official capacities and the barrels of the gun to trample on the rule of law through savage attacks against defenseless individuals.

In doing so, they hurt, force, or take advantage of people who can't defend themselves, causing deaths, damage to property, and violations of their rights to justice. In response to these kinds of attacks, it has become normal for security guards to say they had nothing to do with them.

Multiple efforts to keep the country safe have relied heavily on the Nigerian Army. The roles range from force to influence to allowing civil officials to normalize matters. While the army might be considered the symbol of the protection of authority with which the public can pledge their support, its link with the civil populace has not always been so helpful. Universal complaints and bad accounts of the army's cruel behavior or misbehavior during operations have had major negative impacts on the efforts to build or enhance mutual trust. (Avey et al., 2011).

The reporting by the print media on the acts of the army elicits, in some groups, a misunderstanding of the army's role and occasionally a distortion of its functions. Since the Nigerian media is meant to work as the watchdog of the society, this study aimed at examining the frequency and content of the coverage of the Army brutality during the Endsars protest at Lekki toll gate, Lagos, from Oct 2020 to March 2021. The major focus of the study is how the Nigerian news media, especially the print media determine, arrange, and present information for public consumption as well as their personal interests. This study finds it obvious to assert that in terms of readership, the Nigerian news media are commercial entities. It is obvious that the audience represents readers, and the news media would be audience-oriented. This entails implementing those content-determining factors that make the news more appealing to the readers. To assess how the Nigerian news media present officers of the Nigerian army. Since the military is more often than not viewed as a body signifying power and incorporates a substantial number of economic operations, it is important to study journalistic reporting of military activities. Language and discourses applied in crime have gained an interest in experts across countries (Giles, 2019). The rising incidence of civilian attacks and brutalization across the globe underscores the need for increased research in this field. Communication experts and journal editors have been warning researchers not to shy away from conducting research in this field.

This motivated an interest in performing a content analysis study of army violence on civilians (Ntomba, 2015).

1.2 Statement of the Problem

Human rights abuses are widespread in Nigeria. This unfortunate scenario is due to decades of military dictatorship in the country (Olayiwola, 2013). It has led to sanctions and all types of condemnations by the international community. Unfortunately, the collapse of the military government and the following enthronement of the democratic regime have failed to abolish or at least reduce the most common human rights abuses in Nigeria which is done by the Military. The Nigerian Army is stated to be guilty of most incidences of human rights breaches. Proven incidents of extrajudicial killings, brutality toward innocent people and open corruption continue to define the Nigerian Army in our promising democracy (Soladoye & Ojo, 2020). For instance, the 2015 Zaria massacre involved the killing of over 300 Shia Muslims in Kaduna State by the Nigerian Army. Another infamous incident is the 2017 Onitsha Bridgehead shooting, where soldiers opened fire on peaceful pro-Biafra protesters, resulting in 150 protesters killed and numerous injuries. Most recently, the 2020 Lekki toll gate massacre where soldiers reportedly shoot at unarmed protesters demanding an end of police brutality which this study is focusing on (Duyile, 2023). Thus, various interpretations have been attributed to the activities of the Nigerian Army; some said it was designed to intimidate people due to human rights violations and served as a tool for the APC-led federal government to further oppress the Nigerian citizen due to the massacre at Lekki tollgate in 2020 (Duyile, 2023).

At the height of this conflict, the media especially the print media, used numerous frameworks to deliver mood reports to their readers. The manner in which these frameworks were used in the various reports surely had some effect on the audience. This is because there is an established

association between the audience's perception of media frames and concerns. However, the media seem to be favorable to the government and utilize separate frameworks when reporting on Army violence in Nigeria. It is believed that the press reported news impartially because they are commercial entities who only care about profit, this requires a content analysis technique adopted by the researcher in the study in order to analyze the coverage of two of the leading newspapers in Nigeria, The Punch Newspaper, created by James Aboderin and Sam Amuka in 1973, and The Nation Newspaper, formed by The Nation Company, L.P. in 2006.

Particularly in urban places like Lagos, Nigerian Army behaviour and its effects on civilian's populations have grown in recent years. In spite of strong national and foreign examination, there is still a considerable knowledge gap about the portrayal of cases of army violence in the media. In particular, how prominent publications publish Army aggression against civilians has a huge impact on how the public feel and how policies are executed.

While a lot of research has already been done on how the media reports military violence, not much of it has been done on how particular newspapers cover this incident. By investigating how The Punch and The Nation Newspaper covered incident of Army brutality against civilians protesting at Lekki toll-gate in Lagos between Oct 2020- March 2021, this study tries to narrow this gap. Studies by Jamiu O. A. et al. (2022), Aderinsola S. B. (2020), and Chigozi E. et al. (2023) focus on police actions, leaving a gap in our understanding of how Army violence is presented in the media. This study tries to fill this gap by focusing on newspaper coverage of army brutality on civilians focusing on 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki tollgate, a particular source of worry, and evaluating the unique setting of Lagos State.

Furthermore, while previous research frequently takes a national viewpoint, they fail to investigate the distinctive characteristics of Lagos as a metropolitan center with distinct

governmental dynamics that influence both occurrences of army brutality and their media portrayal. By limiting the geographic scope to Lagos and the time range to Oct 2020 to March 2021, this study presents a targeted and timely investigation of the latest changes in media coverage of military attacks against civilians.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The specific objective is:

1. To evaluate the frequency of coverage of army brutality incidents during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate in *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers between Oct 2020 - March 2021.
2. To analyze how *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers framed army brutality story during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate incident between Oct 2020- March 2021.
3. To ascertain the level of prominence given to stories on army brutality during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate in *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspaper between Oct 2020- March 2021.

1.4 Research Questions

1. What is the frequency of articles covering army brutality during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate incidents published in *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers?
2. How did *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers frame incidents of army brutality in their reporting during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate?

3. What level of prominence was given to stories on army brutality in The Punch and The Nation newspaper during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate?

1.5 Scope of the Study

This study effort will focus particularly on the coverage of Army brutality against civilians in 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate, Lagos. An urgent topic that reflects broader concerns about human rights and governmental power. In other words, this study will concentrate particularly on the coverage of Army brutality against civilians in 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate, Lagos. Given the multiplicity of newspapers functioning within the country, this analysis will be purposely restricted to two notable publications: The Punch and The Nation. By picking these specific sites, the research attempts to give a content analysis that emphasizes differences and similarities in their reporting techniques and editorial choices.

This covers a six months period that provides for a complete investigation of how these newspapers respond to incident of army brutality at Lekki toll-gate as they unfold. During this period, the study will examine important components, such as the frequency of reports, the tone utilized in the narrative, and the framing tactics employed by each newspaper organization. By extensively evaluating these factors, the research will attempt to understand how each newspaper influences public opinion and discourse surrounding military conduct and human rights breaches.

1.6 Significance of the Study

This study focuses on Nigerian Army brutality via the newspaper industry. Thus, the study studies The Punch and The Nation Newspaper, which is referred to as the press and also part of the fourth estate of the realm (Amodu, et al, 2014). This study illustrates the benefits of newspapers even in the present day, as technology has dominated the media business. It is

significant to the field of journalism, students, scholars, lecturers, and society at large. Also, people acknowledge to what extent the newspapers have performed the duty of watchdog or conscience to society and what style it accomplishes it, whether objectivity or sentimentality (Antonis, et al 2022).

This study is of the utmost importance because it is a huge opportunity for the researcher to enhance both their personal and intellectual talents. As a result of this investigation, the researcher will be able to develop his analytical skills and critical thinking abilities, which will allow him to approach the subject matter with a more detailed viewpoint, because of this more thorough knowledge, not only does his academic path become more joyful, but it also affords him the potential to make vital contributions to conversations about human rights and media ethics (Febblina, 2023).

The purpose of this study is to investigate the coverage that was provided by The Punch and The Nation Newspaper during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate. The conclusions of this study will shed light on the substantial role that the media plays in constructing popular narratives surrounding the Nigerian army brutality during the 2020 EndSars protest in Lekki toll gate, Lagos. Not only will it examine the frequency and tone of reports, but it will also investigate the greater ramifications of these narratives on public awareness, civic activity, and the collective consciousness of society. In order to evaluate the influence that journalism has on public opinion and its potential to develop a culture of accountability and openness, it is vital to have working knowledge of the varied methods by which different media outlets express these concerns (Muktar, 2022). An additional characteristic that contributes to the significance of this study is the exploration of the function of the media as a watchdog in society and what way it accomplishes it, whether objectively or sentimentally. The crucial obligation of correctly and

humanely exposing breaches of human rights inevitably lies on the shoulders of journalists, particularly in instances where the transgressions include powerful institutions such as the military. In other words, journalists are the ones who have to accurately and sensitively report on violations of human rights. This is especially true when strong institutions like the military are involved.

The conclusions of this study will offer insight on the ways in which successful media coverage may hold authorities accountable and battle for justice, consequently emphasizing the ethical obligations that are fundamentally related with the activity of journalism. In other words, this study will expose if the newspaper organization are abiding with ethical standards of journalism (Abass, et al 2022). By comparing how The Punch and The Nation Newspaper accomplish or fail these obligations, the study will give insight on the vital necessity for an ethical press that can safeguard civil freedoms and promote justice in a democratic society.

The predicted outcomes of this study will lead to a fuller understanding of the complex interplay between media, military power, and civic liberty. It will underline the significance of a robust and ethical press in safeguarding democracy and developing an informed public in Nigeria. As the country grapples with issues of governance and human rights, the insights acquired from this research will be important for policymakers, civil society organizations, and activists striving to promote accountability and preserve civilian rights. In addition to its worth for the researcher, this study offers considerable implications for the academic community, particularly for future researchers interested in the interconnections between media and military authority. By offering a framework for subsequent study, it will generate continuous scholarly discourse, enabling fresh inquiries into how media portrayals effect public perceptions and influence policy responses. The

findings will expand current literature and contribute to the design of protocols that future studies can reference, fostering a culture of rigorous academic study in this critical area.

Moreover, the significance of this research extends to its ability to empower communities. By underscoring the role of the media in publicizing army atrocities, the study equips citizens with the knowledge required to demand responsibility and justice. An informed public is crucial to the health of democracy since it drives civic engagement and creates a collective commitment to human rights. This study finally tries to bridge the gap between media narratives and public action, proving the idea that informed citizens are key advocates for justice and ethical government. This work not only highlights a personal journey for the researcher but also contributes to a broader discourse on media, military power, and human rights. By studying the coverage of army violence in Lagos, it tries to develop a broader understanding of the essential role that journalism plays in defining societal standards, holding power accountable, and advocating for the rights of all individuals. There are several methods, but my study will focus on the quantitative method. This allows for the collection of numerical data, which is vital in establishing the amount of newspaper coverage (Shava, 2021). For example, you can count the number of articles published on army cruelty, the number of times particular terms (e.g., army brutality, military, civilian casualties) occur, or the amount of space (in words or column inches) dedicated this study's topic. You can measure if coverage increased or reduced at certain intervals, maybe in reaction to specific happenings (Abu, 2020).

There are different theories in mass communication, but for the purpose of this study, it is only agenda-setting theory and framing theory that are significant to this study because it wants to explore how The Punch and The Nation prioritize and the slant or bias in reporting the issue of

army brutality in Lagos These theories will help in tying the topic to an existing study being carried out by another researcher (Patricia et al, 2016). The theories provide an organized technique to examine the phenomenon, and it will give significant insight on how and why the media influences public opinion of the issue (Parveen, 2017).

1.7 Limitations to the Study

The first drawback of this study is the methodology (content analysis) it just provides valuable insights; it may not fully capture the complexity. It only works with what is published. If a newspaper chooses not to print particular stories or opinions, such voices are removed from the analysis. It's quantitative (counting) it may miss deeper qualitative understanding. Another limitation is the time-frame (October 2020 - March 2021). The study focuses on a specified time-frame from October 2020 - March 2021, which is vital for its scope and analysis. This temporal limitation may offer major concerns regarding the application and generalizability of the findings. Focusing simply on this six-month period, the research may overlook wider patterns in media coverage and shifts in public opinion concerning military operations and civilian interactions in Nigeria. Another restriction is the geographic limitation; this study is geographically confined to Lagos State, implying that only Lagos will directly profit from its findings. Other states shall be excluded from consideration as beneficiaries. This constraint is deliberate, as the study is restricted to Lagos and does not intend to capture instances or media coverage outside this area.

1.8 Operational Definition of Terms

The following terms are more relevant to the study.

Frequency: In the context of this study, frequency refers to the number of times reports involving incidents of army brutality appeared in The Punch and The Nation periodicals between Oct 2020 and March 2021.

Prominence: Prominence within the context of this study means stories on Army abuse as appear in The Punch and The Nation Newspaper in terms of front page, inside page, or back page between the given time of study.

Frame: Frame in this context of study explains how the two selected newspapers make the public view the narrative involving Army brutality, i.e., positive, negative, or neutral.

Army Brutality: Within this context of research, it refers to when soldiers use unreasonable force on civilians, such as beating, arresting, and shooting people without any tangible basis.

Military Force: within this context of study, it refers to armed personnel who uses weapons that should be used to protect and maintain the order of the country to harm and cause violence against civilians in Lagos.

Human Right: in this context of study, it's the fundamental freedom the civilians are entitled to in order not to be maltreated by military personnel.

Oppression: In this context of study, it's the misuse of power and weapon by the military to maltreat or cause violence against civilians.

Injustice: In this context of study, it refers to an instance where civilians face unlawful violence, harassment, intimidation or any form of rights infringement by the military without due legal justification.

Coverage: within this context of study, coverage refers to the manner and accuracy in which the selected newspaper report incident of army brutality on civilian in Lagos between January 2024 to June 2024.

CHAPTER TWO

LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter presents the literature review of this project. The chapter is sectioned into three parts, namely, conceptual review, theoretical review and empirical review.

The traditional role of the media in any society is to educate, inform and entertain. These roles are so crucial that societies can hardly progress meaningfully without these channels of Mass Communication. Thomas Jefferson, while underscoring the importance of the press in the society in one of his speeches stated: “.... Were it left for me to choose whether we should have a government without newspapers or newspapers without government, I shall not hesitate a moment to choose the latter” (Nwabueze and Ebele 2013).

Traditionally, mass media are set up to serve certain functions in the society. The basic functions are information, education, entertainment and surveillance. In performing these roles, therefore, the mass media has the power and can serve as the agents for bringing to the notice of Nigerians certain actions and actors that are capable of threatening the country’s national security (Ukonu and Tafamel, 2011).

According to Happer and Philo (2013), the media plays a central role in influencing the manner in which public reacts about what happens in the world particularly in those areas in which audiences do not possess direct knowledge, access or experience. There is no doubt that the media has impact on perception, attitude and belief of people over various issues particularly the brutality perpetrated by the Nigerian Army in Lagos.

Due to their power, mass media have a role to play in supporting the federal government in combating insecurity in Nigeria by enforcing attitude, beliefs and perception of the people about the brutality.

Whether we are aware of the effects of the media or not, the information we got from it had a big impact on how we saw the world. Because the reporters couldn't cover every single event that happened every day, they had to pick and choose what to write about. Picking which stories to include was the first step in making news, which was why it was so easy to change the truth. (Chan and Chan, 2012).

2.1 Conceptual review

2.1.1 The Nigerian Army

According to the Nigerian Army Handbook (2022), the history of the Nigerian Army dates to 1863, when Lt Glover of the Royal Navy selected 18 indigenes from the Northern part of the country and organized them into a local force, known as the "Glover Hausas" (Because of the secret nature of the Nigerian Military, it was impossible to get information from the Defense Headquarters. Even efforts to get some university course mates of the researcher to get information did not yield Results). Glover, who was governor of Lagos, used the small force to punish people in the area around Lagos and protect the trade lines that went around the city. It was called the "Hausa Constabulary" when the "Glover Hausa" turned into a regular police force in 1865. For the Lagos colonial government, it was both a police force and a military base. It changed its name to "Lagos Constabulary" over time. It changed its name to "Lagos Battalion" when it joined the West Africa Frontier Force (WAFF) in 1901.

The Royal Niger Company (RNC), the Nigerian Constabulary Force in 1886, and the Oil Rivers irregular in 1891 were also sent by the British government. In 1889, Lord Fredrick Lugard had formed the incipient body of what was to be known in 1890, as the West Africa Frontier Force, (WAFF), in Jebba, Northern Nigeria (Nigerian Army Handbook, 2022).

The Royal Niger Company (RNC) Constabulary units in Northern Nigeria were added to the new unit, which made it bigger. By the end of 1901, it had combined all paramilitary units in the other British dependencies into its command, thus fully meriting its designation "WAFF". The establishment of West Africa Frontier Force (WAFF) led to the merger of all groups into regiment in each of the dependencies. The merger in Nigeria created the Northern Nigerian Regiment and Southern Nigerian Regiment. The First leaders of the Southern Regiments of WAFF were Lt CHP Carter (1899-1901) and Col J Wilcox (1900-1909) respectively. The two regiments were eventually used for expeditions during the annexation of Nigeria by Lord Lugard between 1901 and 1903 (Nigerian Army Handbook, 2022).

With the amalgamation of Nigeria in 1914, the unification of the Northern and Southern Regiments came into being and this marked the birth of the Nigerian Regiments. The Northern Nigerian Regiments became the 1st and 2nd Battalions of the Nigerian Regiment, while the Southern Nigerian Regiment became the 3rd and 4th Battalions of the Nigerian Regiments (NR). The Mounted Infantry of the Northern Regiments became the regular Infantry Battalion after the Second World War. A field gun also existed in the Northern Regiment.

With the visit of Queen Elizabeth of Britain between 28 January and 15 February, 1956, the Nigerian unit was renamed the Queens Own Nigerian Regiments (QONR). Also in the same year, the regionalization of the WAFF came into life and each military force became independent of the other. As a result, the QONR became the Nigerian Military Force (NMF). By 1st June, 1958, the British Army Council in London surrendered control of NMF to the Nigerian Government. In 1960, when Nigeria became independent, the NMF became known as the Royal Nigerian Army (RNA). When Nigeria became a country, the RNA changed to the Nigerian Army. The same

year, the Army replaced the RWAFF's dress, rank system, and equipment with new ones, including as the green khaki uniform (Nigerian Army Handbook, 2022).

For economic reasons and Nigeria's danger perception, the strength was structured into three Infantry Divisions and Lagos Garrison Organisation (LGO). In 1982, there was another reorganization of the NA. Emphasis was put on increased mobility and improved firepower. That exercise marked the beginning of the idea of mechanization of the NA. To make the structure successful, the NA procured more sophisticated equipment and trained more personnel on operational and professional courses locally and abroad.

There were numerous mortars, antitank guided weapons, recoilless launchers, air defense guns, surface-to-air missiles, and surveillance vehicles in the army, along with 236 main battle tanks, 140 light tanks, 317 tracked armored personnel carriers, 127 wheeled armored personnel carriers, 542 reconnaissance vehicles, 49 self-propelled artillery, 109 towed artillery, and 21 multiple rocket launchers. Most of this equipment was not usable (Nigerian Army Handbook, 2022). Between 2001 and 2008, the Nigerian Armed Forces went into contractual agreements and/or taken delivery of the following:

NINE Mi-34 helicopters, SIX Mi-35P gunships, Mi-24 gunships, FOUR Mi-17 utility choppers, SEVEN Agusta A109 Power helicopters, FOUR Agusta A139 helicopters, A total of 77 T-72 tanks, 16 AMX-30 tanks, 50 extra T-55 tanks, 67 MT-LB APC/IFVs, 193 Otokar Cobra APCs, 47 BTR-3 APCs, 18 BTR-70 APCs, 6 BTR-60 APCs (likely free equipment from Russia), 18 Panhard M3 APCs, 70 more 8X8 MOWAG APCs, 18 more Oto Melara 105 mm howitzers, 23 more Palmaria 155mm self-propelled howitzers, and 48 BOFORS Archer 155 mm gun-howitzers (Nigerian Army Handbook, 2022).

The poor economic situation of the 1990s necessitated a review of Nigeria's defense policy and the restructuring of the NA to match with the economic facts of that time. The time coincidentally witnessed more of NA's involvement in various Internal Security (IS) operations, participation in peacekeeping operations and the imbroglio with Cameroon over Bakassi Peninsula. In addition to these, Nigeria was apprehensive of possible conflicts with her other countries. It would take a well-structured force with appropriate manpower and equipment to meet these challenges.

2.1.2 Concept of Military brutality against civilian

The concept of military brutality is found within the confine of unlawful use of force against civilians. Military is meant to use force and engage in violence as “the actual or threatened use of violence is one of the essential characteristics of the military (Kümmel and Klein, 2013). More precisely, the military is a “social organization for the achievement of political aims through the threatened and actual use of armed force” (Wachtler, 2016). However, in many literatures, brutality is used within the context of violence against civilian. Therefore, violence against civilians broadly to refer to any acts that, through the use of force, harm or damage civilians or civilian targets, including lethal as well as nonlethal forms of violence (Balcells and Stanton, 2020).

2.1.3 Concept of civilian

Under the International Humanitarian Law, Individual civilians, or those who do not fit into any of the several divisions of combatants, comprise the civilian population. Under international humanitarian law, people are generally protected from the risks associated with military operations, and some civilian groups are entitled to more protection than others.

However, Additional Protocol I to the 1949 Third Geneva Convention expanded it in 1977 to provide equal protection to all combatants. The definition provided to civilians is further expanded. According to the protocol, a civilian is any individual who does not belong to one of the following groups: the regular armed forces, even if they claim loyalty to a government or authority that the opposing power does not recognize; the armed forces of a party to the conflict, as well as militias or volunteer corps that are a part of such armed forces; or any organized groups and units, provided that they are under a command that is in charge of the behavior of its subordinates, even if the party to the conflict to which they respond is represented by a government or authority that is not recognized by an adverse party. This final type comprises small armed groups and organized resistance movements (GCIII Arts. 4.a.1–3, 4.a.6; API Arts. 43, 50).

For this reason, academics have also defined a combatant as a soldier who controls a weapon or does any other job associated with the military effort, and a civilian as a noncombatant. However, civilians are not a homogenous population; there is significant variance in civilians' involvement and interactions with armed groups, even within a single conflict (Gowrinathan & Mampilly 2019, Petersen 2001, Wood 2003, Balcells, 2017).

2.1.4 Military and Civilian relationship

The relationship between the military and civilian population comes under civil-military relations in academia. It has been severally defined but with the same meaning. Aboluwoye (2019) described civil-military relations as the totality of relations and interactions between the military personnel and the civilians in any political system, because of this, academics have also defined a civilian as a noncombatant, and a combatant as a soldier who controls a weapon or does any other duty associated with the military effort. The relationships and cooperation of

civilians with armed organizations, however, vary significantly, even within a single conflict (Gowrinathan & Mampilly 2019, Petersen 2001, Wood 2003, Balcells, 2017).

Furthermore, Aboluwoye (2019) said that civil-military relations can take up any form in a state. Citing Finer (1962), he described four types of civil-military relations as follows:

The first is that, like all other pressure groups, military officials can use their legitimate authority to influence the civilian government in order to accomplish specific goals, like raising the budget. Even while the military can have a significant impact on policy as an interest group, its ability to contest the civilian government's choice is limited.

Second, military personnel can utilize threats of punishment or blackmail to accomplish their objectives. This is primarily theoretical because the Nigerian military's use of threats against the civilian government is punishable by death and is regarded as treason.

Thirdly, a civilian government may be overthrown by the military and replaced by another civilian government. This could occur if the previous civilian government has not fulfilled its national obligations.

The military leaders' decision to overthrow a civilian administration and assume control of state activities is the final civil-military relationship that Finer defined.

2.1.5 Newspaper

The mass media have different functions they are expected generally to play in society. This expectation of society of the media draws from the extent of its reach the mass media through its various individual vehicles pervades almost all areas of society and is not bound by economic, social, political, cultural and even national lines and their inherent ability to influence society, as explained implicitly and explicitly in media effect theories and studies (Flew and Sal, 2005; Barker, 2001; Folarin, 2005). Traditionally, according to media modelers in the 1960s including

Harold Lasswell, and Richard Wright, the media are expected to perform the functions of information providing through surveillance, correlation, cultural transmission, and entertainment. Other functions such as servicing the economy, education, etc. have been added following research into the roles that the media play in society based on empirical observation. The role of mass media is to disseminate information so that everyone is well informed and a consensus is reached regarding a particular topic. They disseminate useful information on health care to help curb the outbreak of certain diseases.

As television, newspapers, the internet, and magazines each constitute a form of mass media, they each possess the ability of focusing our attention on a particular matter. This is what agenda setting theory refers to.

Policymakers also think to derive a good deal of information from the media. As Bryant and Thompson (2012) stated, “news reporting of social issues attains a great deal of importance that can influence the perception of normal people and influential policy makers alike.” It has also been established that the news media attempt to deepen their coverage of public issues and concerns as they impact the society’s mainstream and/or the majority of people in its audience. The principal objective of newspapers is to disseminate information. They publish ‘news’, which is commonly small reports of occurrences. They publish ‘features’ as well, which are articles on a given topic, and ‘editorials’ which are opinions on a particular matter. According to Gupta and Sinha, (2010), newspapers have the capacity reach many people, very quickly. They can play a very important part in increasing people’s knowledge about issues in the society that affects (or has the potential to affect) them.

Babalola, (2002) referred to Cheyney, (1992) and used their definition in a way that shows that a newspaper is a publication that provides current information on local, state and world events. It

also provides up-to-date, sharp criticism of music, theatre, television, and the fine arts, executive and legislative decisions, and even columns and comics to entertain the readers. A newspaper can be read and understood by every literate and illiterate person, whether student or worker, old or young, elite or peasant, in any society. The reason is that all the groups of readers mentioned above can find a lot of things to their liking in a newspaper.

The newspapers of our time utilize design elements like story layout, typeface, and illustrations to facilitate the retrieval of information for the reader. Significant stories are usually placed at the top of a page. The most important stories have large bold headlines. Illustrations appear next to related stories (Babalola, 2002). The universal format of a newspaper presents information in a predictable way. In a straight news story, the headline gives the reader the main idea of the story. The lead paragraph gives a summary of the story in capsule form, answering the important newspaper questions who, what, when, where, why and how. The remainder of the news story provides additional details, with the least important information at the end of the story.

The printed newspaper as it has come to be known today has a history of virtually 400 years, during which all over the world, the daily events that affect the lives of ordinary people have been written, discussed, photographed, satirized, praised and analyzed. It is a captivating, direct source for not only history, but also fashion and art, commerce and values, culture, politics and thousand seemingly trivial things that people want to know about. In every language, the newspaper is an inimitable, most important source not only for current and future information needs (Ronan, 2015).

Newspapers are still the most significant outlet for news and other types of written communication. Newspaper's record, print and publish stories of events that are of importance to the society at any given time. They are respected and credible records of the significant issues

and events as and when they occurred. They provide excellent memories of a country's historical events and landmarks. They are sources of textual evidence useful to students, researchers, journalists, administrators, lawyers, politicians, and the larger society (Nakiganda, 2017).

Newspapers, according to Onwubiko (2015), have been accorded a great deal of importance in the transmission of government policy, priority changes and even interest changes. Newspapers are noted as regular sources of primary and up-to-date information. Student, scholars, administrators, the barely literate, and so on, have high demand for newspapers through self-acquisition, exchange, and borrowing from friends, relatives and from libraries

2.2 Theoretical Framework

The study adopted the Agenda Setting Theory. Agenda-setting theory sees the media as instruments used to influence public opinion by “setting the agenda in public discourse”. The theory states that when issues are covered by the media as often as possible, the public would take them to be important (Wanta 1997, cited in Wallinger, 2010).

The theory was derived from the work of Walter Lippman in 1922, who argued that “the public responds not to actual events in the environment but to the pictures in our heads” (LittleJohn and Foss, 2008), that the “news media construct our view of the world” (Coleman et al, 2009). Later, (McCombs and Shaw, 1972) conducted a study on “The Agenda Setting Function of the Mass media,” They conducted a study during the 1968 presidential campaign. They analysed the political news contents of the mass media used by Chapel Hill voters during campaign (four local newspapers, The New York Times, the news magazines Time and Newsweek, and the NBC and CBS evening news broadcast) McCombs and Shaw found an almost perfect correlation between the issues listed by voters as most important and the topics that were given the most

space, time, prominence in the news media. Additionally, the priority given by the media to coverage of those issues almost perfectly matched the relative amounts of time or space given by the media to the coverage of those issues (Littlejohn and Foss, 2019).

Agenda-setting theory relates to how issues of public concern are derived from the issues covered by the media (McCombs and Ghanem, 2006). Public opinion is influenced by the elements of news chosen and sifted by the media, which makes the audience think along a certain pattern (Fourie, 2001). Consequently, the topics the media chooses to cover and how they cover these topics are criteria of the theory. Determining what qualifies as news is the responsibility of the news gatekeepers such as reporters, writers, and editors (Sanchez, 2002; Dainton and Zelly, 2011).

The significance of news stories in a newspaper is determined by their position. The most important news items are used as headlines, are written in bold, and are placed on the front page. In broadcast media, important news items are reported first, in detail, and others are reported later. As DeFleur (2010) puts it, “stories judged [by editors or news directors] to be of somewhat lesser importance or newsworthiness occupy the back pages, or the last part of the broadcast.” As a theory of mass communication, it has stood the test of time, and proved to be deep and wide; (Coleman et al, 2009) this is because many studies have confirmed its validity (Shehata, 2010; Uscinski, 2009).

Agenda-setting is the creation of public awareness and concern of salient issues by the news media. Two basis assumptions underlie most research on agenda-setting: (1) the press and the media do not reflect reality; they filter and shape it; (2) media concentration on a few issues and subjects leads the public to perceive those issues as more important than other issues. One of the most critical aspects in the concept of an agenda-setting role of mass communication is the time

frame for this phenomenon. In addition, different media have different agenda-setting potential. Agenda-setting theory seems quite appropriate to help us understand the pervasive role of the media (for example on political communication systems). Cohen, (1963) states not to be successful much of the time in telling people what to think, but it is stunningly successful in telling its readers what to think about.”

Although the public's agenda is supposedly set by the media, it is thought that the opposite may occasionally occur, with "the public's agenda occasionally influencing the media's issue agenda" (Uscinki, 2009). According to Uscinki, this leads to two "competing frameworks" among researchers: the audience-driven framework, where the audience agenda impacts the news media, and the agenda-setting framework, where the news agenda influences the public agenda. When covering news, reporters will take into account the story's pertinence and the audience's interest in "exciting spectacular events like violence, conflict, scandal, or disaster" (Graber, 1980, cited in Uscinki, 2019). The audience will have an impact on the media agenda if news articles are covered according to their audience relevance.

Uscinki contends that reporters will cover environmental news because of the public's interest in topics like "environmental clean-ups." The actions of influential people, such as the president of a nation, whose remarks on national issues may be selected by the media and used as news stories, or certain interest groups that have the power to set the agenda by taking a position on a matter, may also have an impact on the media agenda (Straubhaar et al., 2010). LittleJohn and Foss (2008) agree and contend that when the media have ties to the elite, the influence of the elite will impact the media agenda. Furthermore, the "public agenda frequently reflects the dormant ideology." Agenda framing theory suggests two approaches. These include surveys and content analysis, which particularly apply to audience interviews (McQuail & Windahl, 1993).

Personal factors can lessen the impact of media agenda-setting on certain audience members, according to Littlejohn (2009). It is less probable that the media will set their agenda for viewers who don't think their agenda is legitimate. Similarly, viewers will be less vulnerable to the media's agenda-setting role if they actively disagree with the news values of the sources they utilize.

Although establishing public agenda is not the focus of this study, it would be intriguing to learn if Nigerian cybercrime has affected media agenda as evidenced by newspaper coverage and representation of the same topic.

Criticism of Agenda Setting Theory

Agenda setting theory has been criticized by several scholars. Aneato et al. (2008) said that the veracity of the theory can be questioned. If people are not exposed to the same media, they will not feel the same issues are important. Considering the plurality of media in this contemporary information age which indicates that the media audiences are consuming different contents at the same time, it is obvious that they cannot ascribe the same importance to the same issues.

Aneato et al (2008) argued that the agenda setting theory failed to clarify whether the information and perception which spread by word of mouth (even when they originate from the mass media) be considered as mass media effects or as interpersonal effects? This question has to be answered for the theory to be properly understood.

The fact that different framing of the same issues can lead to different perceptions of the issues by the media audiences has been part of the criticisms of agenda setting. Watson (2003) posited that it will very likely be transmitted through different frames and thus may have varying impact upon public perception and the public agenda.

Folarin (1998) insisted that despite the criticism of agenda setting, it is generally agreed that it has a strong enough basis in logic and experience. McLuhan (1968) concluded that the press can colour.

Framing Theory

Similar to the agenda-setting tradition, framing broadens the scope of the study by concentrating on the core of the problems rather than a specific subject. The media draws attention to specific occurrences and then situates them within a field of meaning, according to the foundation of framing theory (Mass Communication Theory (Online), 2017).

According to framing theory, people's decisions about how to absorb information are influenced by the way something is presented to them, or "the frame." Abstractions called frames are used to shape or arrange the meaning of messages. The frame that the news or media put on the material they present is the most prevalent application of frames.

The media establish this frame by presenting news items with predetermined and limited contextualization, according to framing theory. Frames are utilized as cognitive shortcuts to connect stories to the larger picture or can be created to improve comprehension. The notion of framing shares similarities with the "second level" of agenda setting, which "examines the relative salience of attributes of issues, as McCombs (2005) and Ghanem (1997) as described in detail," but there is a clear conceptual crossover between the two (Weaver, 2007). Although the word "level" suggests that characteristics are more particular than objects, this agenda of attributes is referred to as "the second level," which differs from "the first level," which has historically concentrated on concerns (objects).

Criticism of framing theory

As valuable as framing theory has been found to be, it is not without criticism owing to the fact that theories always fall short in certain areas. Since its emergence, framing has established itself as one of the most prominent areas of study within the political communication literature, according to (Carnahan, Hao and Yan, 2019). Simply defined, the authors continued, frames are communication actions that offer a certain perspective on the world, which has the power to alter how individuals see, categorize, and assess problems and occurrences. Framing methodology has not changed much since the notion was first introduced several decades ago, despite the fact that scholarly knowledge of framing as a concept has improved as a result of years of fruitful debate. As a result, the techniques used to research and comprehend framing effects have not been able to keep up with more recent conceptualizations of framing and have found it difficult to make a significant contribution to the field of framing theory as a whole. The current state of the literature, which is characterized by inconsistencies and peculiarities across individual works, has made generalization challenging and impeded further theoretical development. In particular, analyses of the framing literature over the past 20 years indicate that framing studies frequently fail to accurately distinguish framing effects from broader persuasion and information effects.

2.3 Empirical review

The central role the press plays when it comes to covering the Nigerian Army brutality on civilian in Lagos has been part of the larger investigation by numerous scholars in different fields, especially Mass Communication and Journalism. Beyond the Army brutality, however, mass media such as radio, television and newspapers daily report a wide variety of issues and scholars have assessed the performance. Some of these studies have been reviewed here.

Chukwuma Alphonsus, Etumnu, Talabi, Fadeyi, Aiyesimoju, Apuke and Celestine (2022) examined how Nigeria's various media outlets cover the banditry that is now raging in some regions of the nation. To describe the study, the authors selected samples from two television stations and two newspapers. They discovered that the issue of banditry in Nigeria was not sufficiently addressed by either TV or media. Newspapers, however, performed better than TV stations in comparison.

Furthermore, Ehigiator and Osasere (2023) carried out a study to determine the extent of newspaper coverage of Kidnapping in Nigeria. Content Analysis method was adopted to carefully collect data from the select newspapers stories published from September to December, 2022. A total of 71 editions of the Guardian and Vanguard newspapers were collated and analyzed. The objectives of the study were to examine the frequency; prominence, format and genre of the stories on kidnapping in the select newspapers so as to measure the extent the print media report kidnapping cases in Nigeria. Findings revealed that the two newspapers under study were fair enough in their coverage of stories on kidnapping. Straight news format took a major lead of the coverage. Findings also revealed that enough prominence were not given to the issue and that the select newspapers dwelt so much on attacks of kidnapping, neglecting security measures and government responses; only few of them were reported in the newspapers. However, the researcher recommended that, Media organisation especially newspapers should work closely with government in order to get detailed and credible information and that the print media should live up their role as the watchdog of the society by engaging in ethical reporting in terms of investigative and interpretative journalism.

In order to determine the degree of adherence or non-adherence to the protest paradigm, Godwin Alfred, Maidin, Ugbor, Too-chukwu Ezegwu, Ikusemiju, Verlunmun Celestine, and Apuke (2024)

evaluated the coverage of the #Endsars protest in Nigerian publications. The writers looked at 216 stories from three different newspapers: The Punch, Daily Post, and Vanguard. The study's goals were determined by the story trigger, frames, and sources utilized to report the #Endsars protest. The results showed that more reports were generated by spontaneous news occurrences than by other triggers. It was also discovered that, although the protest target's voice was heard more in the stories, the riot frame was the one most frequently utilized when covering the #Endsars demonstration. These results led to the conclusion that Nigerian publications' coverage of the #Endsars movement followed the protest paradigm. Additionally, it was suggested that as the data generated for the current study is limited to allow for generalization, more research be done using a larger sample of media genres and protest types, and that journalists be trained on how to report sensitive issues like protests in the areas of voices to be allowed and frames used. Additionally, Shadrach and Tsokwa (2024) conducted study to examine how protests and protestors were primarily depicted negatively by the media, which failed to acknowledge their acts and reduced their ability to make demands. In light of how Nigerian newspapers covered the statewide #EndBadGovernance protest, the authors investigated the viability of the PP argument. From July 1st to August 5th, 2024, articles from four Nigerian newspaper The Punch, Daily Trust, Premium Times, and Vanguard were subjected to content analysis. According to the findings, media coverage of the statewide #EndBadGovernance protest was consistent with the fundamental tenets of the Protest Paradigm hypothesis, which depicted protest mostly through the prism of rioting, emphasizing violence, altercations, and property destruction. Instead of being portrayed as a valid exercise of citizens' rights that is essential to bolstering democracy and governance, this portrayal portrayed protest as a bad thing that should be discouraged. According to the authors' results, the #EndBadGovernance nationwide protest in Nigeria received

sensational media attention, depriving demonstrators of the necessary voice and support to help push for social change in the country.

Similarly, Ovbiagele and Isah (2023) carried out research to determine how selected newspapers covered the 2020 *EndSARS* Protest in Nigeria. The authors drafted four objectives for the study to which dwell on determining the coverage the select Nigerian newspapers gave to the *EndSARS* protest, finding out the prominence given to the *EndSARS* protest; ascertaining the journalistic genres used in the reportage of *EndSARS* protest and determining the tone of reportage of the *EndSARS* protest by the select Nigerian newspapers. With framing theory as theoretical framework, the authors used content analysis method for data gathering purposes. All the editions of The Daily Sun and the Guardian newspapers published between October, 2020 and March, 2021. Between October 1st, 2020 and March 31st, 2021, the Daily Sun and Guardian newspapers published a total of 182 editions each. The findings showed that the Guardian newspaper gave more attention to *EndSARS* protest than the Daily Sun newspaper. They also showed that most stories were not considered important to be placed on the front pages of the newspapers, there was a gross under-representation or engagement of the public and the Daily Sun carried more favourable items than The Guardian newspaper. The authors concluded that the select newspapers did not give adequate to the 2020 *EndSARS* protest. In addition to incorporating elements of Halliday's systemic functional linguistics (SFL), the writers embraced Van Leeuwen's depiction of social actors. Four popular Nigerian newspapers The Guardian, The Punch, The Nation, and The Sun were used to gather the data. The time frame that was addressed was 2020–2021. Protesters were portrayed as "economic saboteurs," "terrorists," and "purveyors of fake news." Leeuwen's representational strategies; activation, association, dissociation, and exclusion were the foundation for these tactics.

Frederick O.O (2024) conducted a study on reprisal attacks by the military and other security agencies against unarmed civilians in Nigeria and Burkina Faso - the bane of human rights abuse. The study employs narrative analysis to highlight the historical, legal and the ethical dimensions of military reprisal, relying on report from human right organization and government documents which can be considered as secondary sources. The study portrays citizens as victim and the military as aggressors. The study identifies systematic violation of human rights by the Nigerian military citing example like the Odi massacre (1999) and the recent events like the Okuama killings (2024). These events involve arbitrary killings, destruction of property. The reviewed study and the pioneer study are related as both studies focus on brutality on civilians. The study is relevant to my study because in his study suggests gaps in narrative of military is accountability which my findings on how The Punch and The Nation report such stories can validate it, thereby contributing to the discourse of public awareness and accountability. The researcher used game theory to analyze how unlawful reprisal attacks by military deviate from the rule of law and undermine sustainable peace but my study won't use game theory because it focusing on how the media portrays brutality story reported. Also, the reviewed study makes use of narrative analysis method to highlight the historical, legal and the ethical dimensions of military reprisal, relying on report from human right organization and government documents which can be considered as secondary sources but my study will be using Content analysis to examine the relationship between variables of the study by using numbers and statistics to explain and analyze its findings.

A study on the comparative analysis of how The Guardian and The Nation newspapers frame police brutality was carried out by Jamiu O. A. et al. in 2022. The goal was to ascertain how frequently news stories about police brutality were covered by The Guardian and The Nation

newspapers, how prominent these stories were in these publications, and which frame The Guardian and The Nation newspapers most frequently used when reporting on police brutality in Nigeria. The framing theory and agenda setting theory serve as the study's theoretical foundations. Using a coding sheet to extract pertinent data, the content analysis method was utilized to produce quantitative data from the chosen newspapers. According to the newspaper research, police violence was covered in 135 of the 181 editions. The results also showed that the human interest frame accounted for 43% of all reports, followed by the consequence frame with 12% and the security, reassurance, and attribution of responsibility frames with 10% each. While the pioneer study focused on newspaper coverage of Army brutality on civilians evaluating The Punch and The Nation newspaper, the reviewed study focused on the comparative analysis of the framing of police brutality by The Guardian and The Nation newspapers. Nevertheless, the two studies are related in that they both examine newspaper coverage and brutality on civilians.

The researcher used framing theory and agenda setting theory to examine how the media's framing and agenda setting influence public perception and understanding of police brutality in Nigeria, this study too will be using framing theory and agenda setting theory because it focusing on how the media portrays brutality story reported and how it influences public perception and understanding of Army brutality in Nigeria. Also, the reviewed study makes use of content analysis to systematically analyze and compare how newspaper frame and prioritize coverage of police brutality to evaluate their influence on public perception and awareness also my study will be using Content analysis to examine the relationship between variables of the study by using numbers and statistics to explain and analyze its findings.

Aderinsola S.B. (2020) carried out a study on online and hardcopy newspapers coverage of police brutality in Nigeria assessing The Punch and Premium times Newspaper. The objective of

the study was to find out the most prevalent cause of police brutality found in Nigerian offline and online newspaper; to determine the type of police brutality that is prevalent in Nigerian hard and soft copy newspapers and to examine the main form of police brutality covered by these newspapers. Agenda setting theory and social responsibility theory was adopted to underpin the study, the research method adopted for this study is content analysis through the use of coding sheets for data collection. Frequency tables and percentages were employed in analyzing specific objectives and the research questions were answered with graphical representations revealing the low coverage of police brutality issues in offline and online newspapers. Based on the findings the media should sit up and start carrying out their responsibilities as information bearers and they should give adequate information about these Police brutality cases. The reviewed study and the pioneer study are related as both studies focus on newspaper coverage and brutality on civilians, but whereas the reviewed study centered on the coverage of police brutality in Nigeria while the pioneer study centers on newspaper coverage of Army brutality on Civilian. The researcher used social responsibility theory and agenda setting theory to examine how the media's social responsibility and agenda setting influence public perception and understanding of police brutality in Nigeria while this study will be using framing theory and agenda setting theory because it focusing on how the media portrays brutality story reported and how it influences public perception and understanding of Army brutality in Nigeria. Also, the reviewed study makes use of content analysis to systematically analyze and compare how newspaper frame and prioritize coverage of police brutality to evaluate their influence on public perception and awareness also my study will be using Content analysis to examine the relationship between variables of the study by using numbers and statistics to explain and analyze its findings.

Chigozi E. et al (2023). conducted a quantitative study on Media Coverage of Police Brutality and ENDSARS Protests in Nigeria. The objective was to examine the frequency of reportage of Police brutality and End Sars protest in Nigeria by Vanguard and Guardian newspapers among others. The agenda-setting theory and social responsibility theory underpinned this study. The population of the study consisted of 246 editions of the newspapers published between 1st October, 2020 to 30th January, 2021: a study period of four months. Krecie and Morgan's guide for sample selection was employed to select 148 issues of the two newspapers as the sample of the study. Data were presented in tables and analysis done using simple percentages. Findings of the study revealed that Vanguard newspaper carried the greatest number of stories on the Police brutality and End Sars issues in Nigeria, compared to the guardian newspapers. The study concludes that the two newspapers gave the Police brutality and End Sars protest issues in Nigeria low prominence in their reportage, but projected the Police brutality and End Sars protest issues in a positive light.

The reviewed study and the pioneer study are related as both studies focus on newspaper coverage of brutality on civilians, but whereas the reviewed study centered on Media Coverage of Police Brutality and ENDSARS Protests in Nigeria while the pioneer study centers on newspaper coverage of Army brutality on Civilian. The researcher used social responsibility theory and agenda setting theory to examine how the media's social responsibility and agenda setting influence public perception and understanding of police brutality and end Sars protest shaped public awareness and fulfilled the media's role in prioritizing and presenting issues responsibly in Nigeria while this study will be using framing theory and agenda setting theory because it focusing on how the media portrays brutality story reported and how it influences public perception and understanding of Army brutality in Nigeria. Also, the reviewed study

makes use of content analysis to systematically analyze and compare how newspaper frame and prioritize coverage of police brutality to evaluate their influence on public perception and awareness also my study will be using Content analysis to examine the relationship between variables of the study by using numbers and statistics to explain and analyze its findings. Based on the empirical review, research on newspaper coverage of Army brutality on Civilian, with existing studies providing indirect insights but lacking comprehensive focus on this specific topic. Further empirical research is needed to fully understand whether the media recurring patterns of violence or isolate incidents by analyzing how the selected newspapers frames brutality incident on civilians and also evaluate whether newspaper coverage adheres to or deviates from standard of responsible journalism in reporting human right abuses.

Finally, Oso and Ajayi (2022) examined how government (agencies) portrayed #EndSARS protesters' ideologies in a few Nigerian press articles.

Okpara, Izuogu, and Omeonu (2023) looked at how President Buhari's management of Nigeria's insecurity was framed in the media from January 2016 to December 2017. Three national dailies the Daily Sun, The Nation, and The Daily Leadership were purposefully chosen with the aim of identifying the sources and tone of news frames for covering President Buhari's handling of Nigeria's insecurity. A total of 732 editions of the chosen newspapers were systematically sampled for the study. According to the study, President Buhari's management of Nigeria's insecurity was framed by the chosen publications using government sources and a neutral tone.

2.4 Gaps to Fill

A research gap occurs when existing studies and literature do not adequately cover a specific subject or feature of a topic, communicating the need for additional exploration. Finding and filling these gaps can help develop awareness and comprehension in the field.

The existing body of research identifies various gaps, which this study aims to address. Most significantly, while earlier studies have thoroughly investigated police brutality, little attention has been paid to the specific issue of army violence against civilians. Some studies focused on police activities, leaving a gap in our understanding of how Army violence is presented in the media. This study seeks to fill this gap by focusing on newspaper coverage of army brutality, a particular source of worry, and evaluating the unique setting of Lagos State.

Furthermore, while previous studies frequently take a national viewpoint, they fail to investigate the relevant characteristics of Lagos as a metropolitan center with separate political and social dynamics that influence both occurrences of army brutality on civilian and their media representation. By limiting the geographic scope to Lagos and the time range to October 2020 to March 2021, this study presents a targeted and timely investigation of the latest developments in media coverage of military attacks against civilians during 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki toll-gate.

Another gap is in the comparative examination of individual newspapers. Although previous study has compared publications such as *The Guardian* and *The Nation* (Jamiu O. A. et al., 2022), there has been no thorough comparison of *The Punch* and *The Nation*. These two publications, which are widely read but differ in editorial style and readership demographics, provide an opportunity to investigate variations in how army brutality is recorded, framed, and presented to the public.

Furthermore, while some studies have applied framing and agenda-setting theories to police brutality, there has been little research into the applicability of these theories to military brutality. This study will fill a theoretical gap by investigating how the framing of events and agenda-setting in media coverage affects popular views of army brutality in Lagos during 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki toll-gate.

Finally, while past research has occasionally addressed the role of the media in upholding journalistic duty, there has been insufficient critical review of whether reporting corresponds to ethical norms, particularly in the context of human rights violations which is compulsory in today's world. The purpose of this study is to determine how well The Punch and The Nation stick to responsible journalism principles when reporting on examples of army brutality which this study is directing its focus to the attack that occur during 2020 EndSars protest at Lekki toll-gate. By filling these gaps, the study will help to advance our understanding of media portrayals of military acts, as well as the implications for public awareness and responsibility.

CHAPTER THREE

RESEARCH METHOD

Introduction

This chapter explains how the study will be carried out and method to be adopted along the line; such as the research design, the population of the study, research sample and technique, sample size, sampling procedure, instrument for data collection, validity and reliability of study instrument test. It is the research methodology that determines how the research will be carried out. The methodology section is very important, because it tells the readers how the research plan to tackle research problems.

3.1 Research Design

A research design is a planned approach use for collecting and analyzing data in order to get response to research questions. According to Claire, et al (2021) Research design is the arrangement of conditions for collecting and analysis of data in a manner that aims to combine relevance to the research purpose with economy in procedure.

The structure of research for this particular study comes from the Positivist Approach. Positivist paradigms align with the hypothetico-deductive model of science, which builds on the verification of a priori hypotheses and experimentation by operationalizing variables and measures. According to this model, the results of hypothesis testing are used to augment science. Studies that fall under positivism generally attempt to find explanatory or causal relationships by quantitative means, where empirically validated results from very large sample sizes are

preferred. Relying on generalizable inferences, replication of results, and controlled experiments offered a backbone of positivist science (Yoon et al., 2020).

This study intends to use the quantitative research design which is used to examine the relationship between variables by using numbers and statistics to explain and analyze findings. (Thomas, 2023). This study intends to employ the content analysis method to examine Nigerian army brutality on civilians during 2020 End Sars protest at Lekki toll-get in Newspaper using The Punch and The Nation, it intends to research between the month of October 2020 - March 2021 covering 6 months of brutality stories reported by the selected newspaper.

3.2 Research Method

The choice of this method was informed by studies affirming that the method ably evaluates. Communication in a systematic, objective, and quantitative manner for the purpose of measuring variables (Boru, 2018).

According to Amy, (2019) content analysis any systematic procedure devised to examine the content of recorded information. The analysis of what is contained in a message which this study will be doing, analyzing how The Punch and The Nation newspaper portray stories of army brutality over civilians.

Content analysis can be both quantitative and qualitative depending on the purpose of the study in both types, you group or code words, themes, and concepts within the texts and then analyze the results. Following the conceptualization of research design as a guide which spells out how data relating to a given problem should be collected and analyzed (Amadi, 2016). This study adopts a quantitative content analysis research method to achieve its purpose, which is

examining the relationship between variables by using numbers and statistics to explain and analyze its findings.

3.3 Population of the Study

A research study population is a set or group of all the units on which the findings of the research are applied, (Shukla, 2020).

The inventory by the Nigerian Press Council (2024) indicates that Nigeria today has 310 newspapers both tabloid and broadsheet published in the country. Most of these newspapers are daily newspapers, weekly while some are being published on Saturday and Sunday. The newspapers are mostly based in Lagos which is home to numerous newspapers and magazines, most privately owned and appear to retain their editorial independence against odds.

The universe is made up of all conceivable elements, subjects or observations relating particular phenomenon of interest to the researcher (Asika, 2019). All editions of the year 2020-2021 published by *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers fall under the universe of the study.

However, not all editions will be studied. The editions within the time-frame of study October 2020 - March 2021 form the sampling frame from which editions were sampled for the analysis. The choice of newspapers is based on the data the researcher sets out to examine and the reliability, accessibility and competence of the Newspaper organization in reporting brutality news stories.

3.4 Sample Size Determination

This study used Census to collect data from the selected newspapers (*The Punch* and *The Nation*). According to Anand (2024), Census involves collecting data from every individual or unit in the

population of interest. It aims to obtain information about every member of the population, leaving no one out.

The justification for this sample size is that the editions selected covered the height period of army brutality at Lekki toll-gate and the reports are important to be studied.

Therefore, all newspaper editions published within the period of October 2020 - March 2021 will be examined, having one hundred and thirty (130) editions each, which add up to two hundred and sixty (260) editions.

Table 3.4.1: Sample size of The Punch and The Nation newspaper (October 2020-March 2021)

S/N	Year	Month	Numbers of Newspaper Editions (Monday - Friday)
1	2020	October	22
2	2020	November	21
3	2020	December	23
4	2021	January	21
5	2021	February	20
6	2021	March	23
	Total	6 Months	130 X 2 newspapers = 260

3.5 Sampling Technique

This research work will be making use of the non-probability sampling method which is also known as purposive sampling. The study covers weekdays editions (Monday to Friday) excluding weekends (Saturday & Sunday) because most newspaper organizations publish soft news on weekends.

3.6 Method of Data Collection

Data collection is the process of gathering and analyzing information about relevant variables in a planned, systematic way that makes it possible to respond to stated research questions and assess results, (Pritha, 2020). The data will be collected with the use of coding sheet, which contains coding units that provide answers to the research questions.

Coding Units

Frequency: This is to determine the total number of Army Brutality stories collected in the selected months of the year (October 2020 - March 2021).

Story Type: This is to determine the format used in reporting the story (News, Feature article, Opinion, Editorial).

Month of Incidence: Either of the selected months of the year (October 2020 - March 2021).

Story Position: This is to determine where the story was placed in the newspaper.

No. of Paragraph: This is to determine the number of paragraphs within which the story was written.

Tone of Story This is to determine if the organization used Positive, Negative or Neutral tone in disseminating the story.

3.7 Research Instrument

Information for this study shall be gathered using coding sheet which entails coding units, this research instrument is suitable for the study because it will allow the researcher to get an in-depth and objective understanding on how the newspaper outlet frames stories of Nigerian Army Brutality on Civilian at 2020 End Sars protest, in order to determine why and how it is important in Lagos state.

Coding Sheet

Coding sheet is a standardized sheet which allows coder(s) to classify data by placing check marks or slashes in predetermined spaces, Wimmer and Dominick (2006, p.163) cited in Msughter (2024). A coding sheet is important because it is used to record findings derived from the entire coding exercise.

3.8 Validity of the Research Instrument

In research, instruments used to gather data are being inspected to know whether they are appropriate instruments or not to be used to measure certain phenomena.

Validity testing affect instrument of data collection only. To validate this instrument, two steps were taken. In the first step, the instrument was submitted to the supervisor for inputs and approval. My supervisor went through, crosschecked and ensured that the objectives of study were captured. The second step was a pilot process. This way, the coding and coding guide were used to capture some newspaper contents. The data collected were analyzed while observed shortcomings were corrected before the actual data collection.

3.9 Reliability of the Research Instrument

According to Hassan (2024), Reliability refers to the degree to which a measurement or test consistently produces the same results when repeated under similar conditions. It ensures that variations in results are due to actual changes in the variable being measured, not inconsistencies in the measurement process. This study makes use of Cohen's Kappa to test the reliability of the study.

3.9.1 Pilot of the Study

The data to be analyzed are recorded implying that they remain the same forever. Which means the data can be relied on in this research work because it would produce the same results as related studies that has been conducted in the past and will be done in the future.

Inter-coder Analysis

The inter-coder reliability measures the level of agreement between those who code media contents for studies that use Content Analysis Method. It is usually performed using Cohen's kappa. For inter-coder reliability analysis of this study, two coders coded the contents of 44 editions of The Punch and The Nation newspapers. Their reliability report is presented in the tables below.

Kappa Interpretation

< 0 - Poor agreement

0-0.20 Slight agreement

0.21 – 0.40 Fair agreement

0.41 – 0.60 Moderate agreement

0.61 – 0.80 Substantial agreement

0.81 – 1.00 Almost perfect agreement

Case Processing Summary

Cases						
	Valid		Missing		Total	
	n	Percent	n	Percent	N	Percent
Coder 1	44	100.0%	0	0.0%	22	100.0%
Coder 2						

Coder 1 crosstabulates Coder 2

			VAR00002 Coder 2		Total
			1.00	4.00	
VAR00001 Coder 1	1.00	Count	14	0	14
		% within VAR00001	100.0%	0.0%	100.0%
		Coder 1			
		% within VAR00002	87.5%	0.0%	63.6%
		Coder 2			
		% of Total	63.6%	0.0%	63.6%
	4.00	Count	2	6	8
		% within VAR00001	25.0%	75.0%	100.0%
		Coder 1			
		% within VAR00002	12.5%	100.0%	36.4%
		Coder 2			
		% of Total	9.1%	27.3%	36.4%
Total		Count	16	6	22
		% within VAR00001	72.7%	27.3%	100.0%
		Coder 1			
		% within VAR00002	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%
		Coder 2			
		% of Total	72.7%	27.3%	100.0%

Symmetric Measures

			Asymptotic		
			Standardized	Approximate	Approximate
			Error ^a	T ^b	Significance
Measure of	Kappa	.792	.137	3.800	.000
Agreement					
N of Valid Cases		44			

a. Not assuming the null hypothesis.

b. Using the asymptotic standard error assuming the null hypothesis.

The results of the inter-coder reliability analysis are Kappa (in Symmetric Measures table) = 0.792 with $p < 0.001$. This means the data sample collected by two coders using the instrument is substantially reliable as there is a great agreement between them.

Reliability Analysis

The overall reliability analysis for this study was performed using Cronbach's Alpha. The results are presented below:

Case Processing Summary

		N	%
Cases	Valid	44	100.0
	Excluded ^a	0	.0
	Total	44	100.0

a. Listwise deletion based on all variables in the procedure.

Reliability Statistics

Cronbach's Alpha	N of Items
.894	2

The analysis was carried out using Cronbach's Alpha. It is presented in Reliability Statistics table which shows the actual value for Cronbach's Alpha. The statistics shows that Cronbach's Alpha of this study is 0.894 or 89.4%. This indicates a somewhat high level of internal consistency of the variables contained in the instrument of data collection.

3.10 Method of Data Analysis

The method of analyzing the collected data is quantitative data analysis. it involves systematic procedures for interpreting the data collected from selected newspaper and data analysis is employed to provide comprehensive insights into the phenomenon. The software for analyzing the data collected is Statistical Package for the Social Sciences (SPSS).

3.11 Limitation of Methodology

The study adopted Content analysis method which means it's based on what the selected newspaper organization has reported, it just provides valuable insights; it may not fully capture the complexity. It only works with what is published. If a newspaper chooses not to report a particular stories or opinions, such voices are removed from the analysis. It's quantitative (counting) it may miss deeper qualitative understanding.

3.12 Ethical Considerations

The researcher is expected to adhere to ethical principles and guidelines throughout the reach process. Ethical consideration includes:

The researcher must obtain a formal letter from the committees that are in charge of editorial issues for project in the institution. This letter is then presented at the selected newspaper organization to give access to the newspaper editions published during the period of October 2020 - March 2021.

This ensure the study is carried out with transparency and integrity, adhering to the ethical standard throughout the study.

CHAPTER FOUR

DATA PRESENTATION, ANALYSIS AND DISCUSSION OF FINDINGS

Introduction

This chapter presents the data analysis, interpretation and discussion of findings for the study. This chapter presents answers to the research questions as described in chapter one of the study using the data that were collected from the two selected newspapers (The Punch and The Nation). The questions were answered by analyzing the data presented in tabular form using SPSS. A total of 260 week-day editions of the newspapers, 120 for each, were analysed October 1, 2020 to March 31, 2021. All the newspapers were found at the University of Lagos Library. Permission was sought before the library could be used. All the editions were analysed for the study.

4.1 Data Presentation and Analysis

In the 260 editions of the newspapers, a total of 183 stories were found on the *Endsars* protest and military brutality in against the civilian population in Lagos. It must be made clear that stories on the *Endsars* in other states were published by the newspapers but only those that covered the Lagos protest were relevant and analysed.

In view of this, only the 183 stories on military brutality in Lagos were analysed. The data were analysed and presented according to the three questions that were raised chronologically in chapter one.

The first research question of the study examined the frequency of articles covering army brutality incidents during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos published in The Punch and The Nation

newspapers between October 2020 and March 2021. When the newspaper articles were analysed, tables 1 and 2 present the findings.

Answer to research question 1: What is the frequency of articles covering army brutality incidents during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos published in The Punch and The Nation newspapers between October 2020 and March 2021?

Table 1: Frequency of articles by months

	Frequency	Percent
October	58	31.9
November	40	21.7
December	45	24.6
January	27	14.5
February	8	4.3
March	5	2.9
Total	183	100.0

Source: Researcher's Computation (2025) using SPSS Output.

Table 1 presents the number of articles published by the newspapers on a month by month basis. As the table shows, October 2020 witnessed the highest articles being published by the newspapers (31.9%). This is due to the fact that although the *Endsars* protest began in the first 10 days of October, the brutality of the civilian population by the army peaked on the 20th of the

month, leading to a death of many protesters as alleged. After October, the newspapers also published 21.7% of the articles in November and 24.6% in December. However, the longer the issue took, the lower the number of articles that were published. Therefore, the first three months see huge interest from the newspapers but the last three months see few articles published. As such, in January, the newspapers published 14.5%. In February, they published 4.3% and in March, they published 2.9%.

Table 2: Frequency of articles by newspapers

	Frequency	Percent
The Punch	98	53.6
The Nation	85	46.4
Total	183	100.0

Source: Researcher's Computation (2025) using SPSS Output.

Table 2 presents the frequency of articles published by the selected newspapers on the army brutality of the civilian population during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos. As the table shows, the two newspapers published a total of 149 articles during the protest in Lagos. Of this number, The Punch published more with 53.6% while The Nation published 46.5%.

The outcomes of tables 1 and 2 show that the selected newspapers paid huge attention to the army brutality during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos by publishing many articles on it. However, the newspapers published huge number within the first three months of the protest and its

aftermath including Panel set up by the Lagos State Government to look into the matter. This answers the first research question.

Answer to research Question 2: On how The Punch and The Nation newspapers framed incidents of Army brutality in their reporting between October 2020 and March 2021

Table 3: Tone of newspaper articles on army brutality

	Frequency	Percent
Positive	67	36.4
Negative	100	54.5
Neutral	16	9.1
Total	183	100.0

Source: Researcher's Computation (2025) using SPSS Output

Table 3 present above the tone of articles published by the selected newspapers on the army brutality of civilian population during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos. The table shows that the newspapers frown at the army brutality of civilian during the protest in Lagos and used harsh tone to report the event (54.5%). On the flip side, they also used government supportive tone to describe the actions of what the army did during the protest where protesters were allegedly killed at Toll Gate in Lekki area of Lagos (36.4%). However, the newspapers were only neutral in few of the articles (9.1%).

Similarly, the study examines how individuals portrayed the 2020 *Endsars* protest in Lagos as against what they portrayed it together. Table 4 below presents the results.

Table 4: Tone of articles by individual newspapers

		Newspaper	
		The	
		The Punch	Nation
Tone of frame	Positive	27	13
		28.6%	15.3%
	Negative	54	44
		57.1%	50.0%
	Neutral	14	31
		14.3%	34.7%
Total		95	88
		100.0%	100.0%

Source: Researcher's Computation (2025) using SPSS Output.

Table 4 presents how the individual newspapers portrayed the 2020 *Endsars* military brutality against civilian in Lagos. As the table shows, the newspapers roundly condemned the civilian brutality by the Army through articles with negative tone. However, The Punch newspaper published more articles with negative tone (57.1%) than The Nation (50%). On the flip side, The Nation was more neutral (34.7%) on the matter than The Punch (14.3%). They were also in

support of the excessive nature of the protesters that led to the brutality (The Punch 28.6% and The Nation 15.3%).

In a similarly vein, the study examines the level of prominence given to the Army brutality of civilian protesters during *Endsars* events of October 2020 and March 2021 in Lagos State in terms of the position and page where the articles were published in the selected newspapers. Tables 5 and 6 present the findings.

Answer to research Question 3: What level of prominence was given to stories on army brutality in The Punch and The Nation newspaper between October 2020 and March 2021 in terms of position and page?

Table 5: Prominence given to Army brutality.

	Frequency	Percent
Front page lead	50	27.3
Front page minor	33	18.2
Inside page	100	54.5
Total	183	100.0

Source: Researcher's Computation (2025) using SPSS Output.

Table 5 presents the prominence given to the Army brutality of civilian populations during the 2020 *Endsars* protest in Lagos State collectively by the newspapers. In the table, most of the articles published by the newspapers on the civilian brutality during the period and event under

examination were published in inside pages (54.5%). However, the combined articles that were given prominence by the newspapers account for the remaining 45.5% with main prominence adds up to 27.3% and minor prominence completes the remaining 18.2%.

Table 6: Prominence given by the newspapers to the story.

		Newspaper	
		The	
		The Punch	Nation
Prominence	1.00 Front page	13	7
	lead	14%	8.5%
	2.00 Front page	16	13
	minor	17.3%	15.0%
	3.00 Inside page	65	67
		68.7%	76.5%
Total		95	88
		100.0%	100.0%

Source: Researcher's Computation (2025) using SPSS Output.

The data in table 6 were disaggregated to show how the newspapers gave prominence to the civilian brutality by the Army during the 2020 *Endsars* protest in Lagos State. The pages where a news article appears determine the prominence given to such article. As such, the two selected newspapers published most of their articles in inside pages (The Punch 68.7%; The Nation 76.5%). However, while The Punch published 14% of its articles on its front pages, The Nation published less than 10% on its front pages. This means in terms of prominence; The Punch gave more prominence to the issue of Army brutality of civilian population during the Endsars protest in Lagos than The Nation newspaper.

4.2 Discussion of Findings

As stated in the preceding chapters, this study examines the Nigerian Army brutality of civilian protesters during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos with The Punch and The Nation newspapers serving as units of observation and their contents as units of analysis between October 2020 and March 2021. The data have been analysed and the findings established. The findings are thereby discussed in this section. They have been related to other relevant scholarly studies in the field of communication and mass media.

The first research question examined the frequency of articles covering army brutality incidents during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos published in The Punch and The Nation newspapers between October 2020 and March 2021. The findings established that the two newspapers, namely, The Punch and The Nation, pay substantial attention to the *Endsars* and the attendant brutality suffered by the protesters and perpetrated by the Army. During the six month period, 183 articles were written on the brutality and they were largely published the first three months of the events. Media are usually attracted to protests. As Council of Europe (2023) opined, protests and demonstrations and the way in which the authorities handled them are matters of legitimate

public interest and the media has a crucial role in providing information on the authorities' handling of public demonstrations and the containment of disorder.

Due to this legitimate public interest, protests inherently attract media attention and protesters significantly rely on media coverage to communicate their demands to authorities (Shadrach and Tsokwa (2024).

Therefore, the 2020 *Endsars* protest in Lagos attracted The Punch and The Nation newspapers and they responded by paying adequate attention it. This obvious response by the media would have ensured that the concern of the protests including the brutality of by the Army attracted the attention of the government and other international stakeholders. The study agrees with the study of Ovbiagele and Isah (2023) where the authors found the level of attention paid to the Army brutality was similar to the current study. This agreement signifies those protests and their attendant consequences such as the Army brutality of civilian in Lagos always attract media attention.

Similarly, the second research question examined how The Punch and The Nation newspapers framed incidents of Army brutality in their reporting between October 2020 and March 2021. The tone of language used by the newspapers was used to measure how the Army brutality of civilian population during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos was portrayed. The findings were presented in two tables and they show that generally, the newspapers were critical of the way the civilian population was brutalized by the Army during the protest. They mostly used negative tone in their coverage. They were also neutral and expressed support to an extent. However, the two newspapers were equally in support of government's response which ensured that the military was drafted to the scene of the protest at Lekki Toll ate and they used phrases such as

'terrorists', 'inconsiderate of other road users', 'economic saboteurs' and 'carrier fake news', 'criminal' etc. to describe the civilian protesters.

In terms of individual newspaper performance, The Punch newspaper was more critical of the brutality than The Nation newspaper but The Nation took a more neutral approach than The Punch.

These findings corroborate those reported by Eke and Opeyemi (2023) where they found that their selected newspapers gave the brutality and *EndSars* protest issues in Nigeria low prominence in their reportage, but projected the brutality and *EndSars* protest issues in a positive light. Similarly, the findings of this study are in tandem with Shadrach and Tsokwa (2024) that how the protest and the attendant brutality was portrayed depicts protest as a negative event to be discouraged, rather than as a legitimate exercise of citizens' rights crucial for strengthening governance and democracy.

As this study has found, both newspapers portrayed the protest and Army brutality of civilian protesters negatively where necessary; positive where necessary and neutral where necessary. So, the newspapers present all sides to the issue.

Furthermore, the study examined the level of prominence given to stories on army brutality in The Punch and The Nation newspaper between October 2020 and March 2021 in terms of position and page. The data collected and analysed on this question revealed that the media gave low prominence to the *Endsars* protest and Army brutality of civilian during the protest by publishing a few articles on the front page as lead story. It was revealed further that majority of the articles were in inside pages. It shows the attention paid to the issue by the newspapers was not given deserving prominence due to the fact that even when the protest was going on in Lagos, other issues were considered more important than the protest.

These findings corroborate James, Muhammad and Josiah (2023) who reported in their study that like the current study, critical tones prevailed, contrasting with supportive tones and minimal neutral tones. Although there was a significant attention to the protests by the newspapers used by the authors, but they gave no prominence on front and back pages to the protest and brutality by the security agencies.

CHAPTER FIVE

SUMMARY, CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

Introduction

This chapter presents the summary, conclusion and recommendation of the study as well as contribution to knowledge and suggestion for further studies.

5.1 Summary

The aim of this study was to investigate the Nigerian Army brutality during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos using *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers between October 2020 and March 2021. Three research objectives and corresponding research questions were designed to guide the study. The objectives were to find out the frequency of articles published in the coverage of army brutality incidents during the *Endsars* protest in Lagos by *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers between October 2020 and March 2021; examine how *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspapers frame incidents of Army brutality in their reporting between October 2020 and March 2021 and the level of prominence given to stories on army brutality in *The Punch* and *The Nation* newspaper between October 2020 and March 2021 in terms of position and page.

In order to collect adequate and relevant data, quantitative design was adopted and content analysis method was used for data gathering. Two national newspapers, namely, *The Punch* and *The Nation*, were used as units of observation while their articles published between October 2020 and March 2021 were used as units of analysis. A total number of 260 editions of the newspapers were found and analysed. In those editions, a total number of 183 articles were found related to the 2020 *Endsars* protest and Army brutality of civilian population in Lagos.

After the analysis, the study found that findings show that the newspapers pay a high attention to the issue of 2020 EndSars protest and Army brutality of the people in Lagos. But The Punch newspaper published more articles on the brutality than The Nation newspaper.

Similarly, the study found that the newspapers published articles that critically condemned the Army brutality of civilian population during the protest in Lagos. Such articles were in the majority of all that was published on the matter. Some of the articles were also neutral, written to only look at the issue at stake and the responses of both state and federal governments. However, some of the articles also portrayed the protesters and those who were brutalized negatively.

Lastly, the study found that the newspapers did not give deserving prominence to the Army brutality of the civilian by publishing most of the articles in inside pages. Only a few of the articles were published on the issue on the front page as lead headline. Therefore, the newspapers gave the Army brutality of civilian protesters in Lagos low prominence. This means it was not important to them.

5.2 Conclusion

From the analysis of the newspaper contents, conclusions can be drawn as follows:

Among others, the study examined the frequency and volume of coverage of Army brutality of the civilian population in Lagos during the EndSars protest in 2020 by the selected newspapers. As the study found, the newspapers deployed lots of time and pages to report the brutality and the entire protest in Lagos and the frequency was often as they published at least two stories in each edition. The conclusion that can be drawn from here is that the protest together with the Army brutality attracted the attention of the selected newspapers in such a way that they responded and gave it their attention.

As the second objective established, the tone of language used in the published articles by the selected newspapers shows that the newspapers were angry and they frowned at not just the protest but also the civilian brutality by the Army. However, they were not only angry at the brutality, the newspapers were also neutral in some articles. They equally showed support for government's response and the draft of the Army to the scene of the protest in Lekki, Lagos. This led to negative portrayal of the protesters.

The study has found that the newspapers accorded low prominence to the articles on Army brutality of civilian during the 2020 *Endsars* protest in Lagos. This shows that although the newspapers paid high attention to the issue, they did not consider it that so important. That is why most of the articles were hidden in inside pages. Only few articles made it to the front page of the newspapers as main headline. In that case, other issues were considered more important than Army brutality of civilian.

5.3 Contribution to knowledge

This study was carried out with aim to establish the mass media framed the Nigerian Army brutality on civilian during the 2020 *Endsars* protest in Lagos using The Punch and The Nation newspapers contents. This study was carried within the field of mass communication and has contributed to existing knowledge by establishing that that media paid high attention to the Army brutality of civilian and in doing so, critically condemned the brutality and refused to support it by given it low prominence.

5.4 Recommendations

Due to the conclusions above, the following are hereby recommended.

1. This study has shown that the selected newspapers dedicated lots of time and pages to the brutality and the entire protest in Lagos. The newspapers have shown that they exist to give voice to all segments of the society including those who are not in support of government's actions and policies. Recommendation is hereby made that government should address the issues that led to the protest across the country especially in Lagos because without the issue of SARS, there would not be protests and Army brutality would not have occurred. As a result, mass media should lend its voice to this call.
2. This study has established that the newspapers used mostly a negative tone of language in the articles they published on the issue to the degree that they became angry and also frown at the entire issue including the protest and the Army brutality of civilians. The findings also revealed that the newspapers were neutral as well as positive in support of the brutality and protest. However, it is wrong for the newspapers to give support for the brutality of the civilians during the protest in Lagos. as a result, it is recommended that the mass media especially newspapers should always side with the people and grievances in order to call government into action that will address the genesis of the protest and the brutality of civilians.
3. It has been determined that the articles on the Army's brutality against civilians during the 2020 Endsars protest in Lagos received little attention from the media. This indicates that even though the subject received a lot of attention from the newspapers, they did not think it was that serious. For this reason, the majority of the articles were concealed behind internal pages. Few articles were featured as the primary headline on the

newspaper's front page. In such instance, the Army's brutality toward civilians was viewed as less significant than other issues. The mass media especially the selected newspapers are hereby advised to project any brutality of civilians by security agencies more by publishing them on the front page in order to create better awareness of such issues.

5.5 Limitations of study

This study is not perfect like other studies in the field of mass communication. There are certain shortcomings and conditions beyond the control of this researcher that place restriction on the outcomes of this study. The major limitation lies in the number of newspapers used to represent mass media in this study. Nigeria has many national newspapers, radio stations and television stations. However, the researcher alone cannot study more than two newspapers considering the fact that there are other critical academic assignments he had soldier simultaneously.

5.6 Suggestion for Further Studies

This study was conducted with only two newspapers, The Punch and The Nation on the Army brutality of civilians during the 2020 Endsars protest in Lagos. Further studies are hereby recommended with other national newspapers in order to establish how they also covered the *Endsars* protest in Lagos.

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Appendix I

CODING GUIDE

For each individual unit of analysis (i.e. editorial content in the newspaper), coders will use this list of 5 descriptive variables (content categories) to document information on an Excel spreadsheet. Serial numbers- Each unit of analysis (editorial content to be coded) is assigned one ID number starting from 1 and ending with the last story. The default: Excel Spreadsheet assigns numbers automatically.

Category 1 - Month

1. October
2. November
3. December
4. January
5. February
6. March

Category 2 – Day

Week days between 1 and 31 of every month

Category 3 – Selected newspapers:

Each of the 2 newspapers has been assigned a unique ID number starting from 1.

1. *The Punch*
2. *The Nation*

Category 4 – Prominence of articles

1. Front page lead
2. Front page minor
3. Inside page

Category 5: Tone of articles

1. Negative
2. Positive
3. Neutral